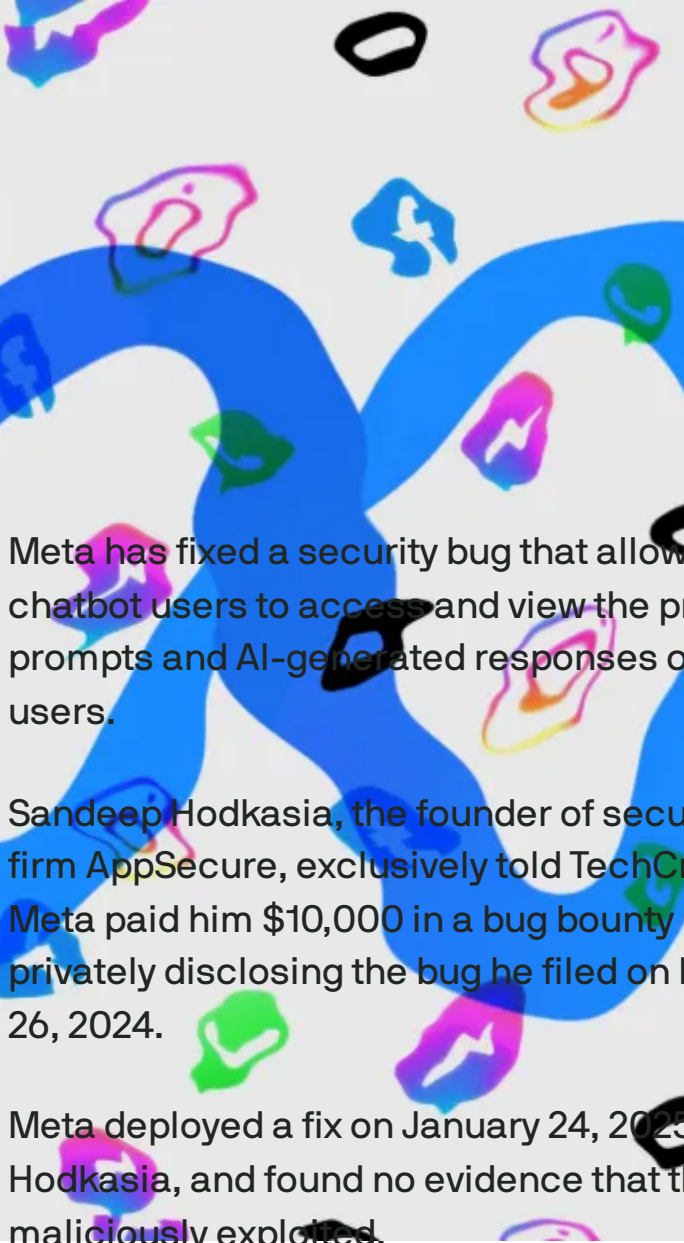


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SECURITY



Meta fixes bug that could leak users' AI prompts and generated content



Zack Whittaker — 1:00 PM PDT · July 15, 2025

Meta has fixed a security bug that allowed Meta AI chatbot users to access and view the private prompts and AI-generated responses of other users.

Sandeep Hodkasia, the founder of security testing firm AppSecure, exclusively told TechCrunch that Meta paid him \$10,000 in a bug bounty reward for privately disclosing the bug he filed on December 26, 2024.

Meta deployed a fix on January 24, 2025, said Hodkasia, and found no evidence that the bug was maliciously exploited.

IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

Hodkasia told TechCrunch that he identified the bug after examining how Meta AI allows its logged-in users to edit their AI prompts to regenerate text and images. He discovered that when a user edits their prompt, Meta's back-end servers assign the prompt and its AI-generated response a unique number. By analyzing the network traffic in his browser while editing an AI prompt, Hodkasia found he could change that unique number and Meta's servers would return a prompt and AI-generated response of someone else entirely.

The bug meant that Meta's servers were not properly checking to ensure that the user requesting the prompt and its response was authorized to see it. Hodkasia said the prompt numbers generated by Meta's servers were "easily

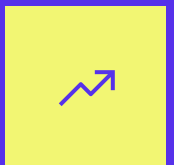
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guessable,” potentially allowing a malicious actor to scrape users’ original prompts by rapidly changing prompt numbers using automated tools.

When reached by TechCrunch, Meta confirmed it fixed the bug in January and that the company “found no evidence of abuse and rewarded the researcher,” Meta spokesperson Ryan Daniels told TechCrunch.

News of the bug comes at a time when tech giants are scrambling to launch and refine their AI products, despite [many security and privacy risks](#) associated with their use.

Meta AI’s stand-alone app, which [debuted earlier this year](#) to compete with rival apps like ChatGPT, launched to a rocky start after some users [inadvertently publicly shared what they thought were private conversations](#) with the chatbot.

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“My assumption is that it’s something you may want to fix because it is directly inside of your infrastructure,” Sadeghipour wrote in the report he sent to Meta, he told TechCrunch. Meta responded to his report, telling Sadeghipour to “refrain from testing any further” while they fix the vulnerability.

The issue, according to Sadeghipour, was that one of the servers that Facebook used for creating and delivering ads was vulnerable to a previously fixed flaw found in the Chrome browser, which Facebook uses in its ads system. Sadeghipour said this unpatched bug allowed him to hijack it using a headless Chrome browser (essentially a version of the browser that users run from the computer’s terminal) to interact directly with Facebook’s internal servers.

Sadeghipour, who found the Facebook vulnerability working with independent researcher Alex Chapman, told TechCrunch that online advertising platforms make for juicy targets because, “there’s so much that happens in the background of making these ‘ads’ — whether they are video, text, or images.”

“But at the core of it all it’s a bunch of data being processed on the server-side and it opens up the door for a ton of vulnerabilities,” said Sadeghipour.

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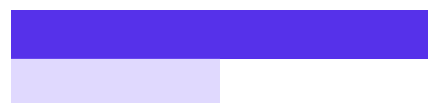
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The researcher said he didn't test out everything he could have done once inside the Facebook server, but "what makes this dangerous is this was probably a part of an internal infrastructure."



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"Since we have code execution, we could've interacted with any of the sites within that infrastructure," said Sadeghipour. "With an [[remote code execution](#) vulnerability], you can bypass some of these limitations and also directly pull stuff from the server itself and the other machines that it has access to."

Meta spokesperson Nicole Catalano acknowledged receipt of TechCrunch's request for comment, but did not comment by press time.

Sadeghipour also said that similar ad platforms that other companies run, and which he has been analyzing, are vulnerable to similar vulnerabilities.

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Meta trials its AI chatbot across WhatsApp, Instagram and Messenger in India and Africa

Manish Singh, Ingrid Lunden

Meta has confirmed to TechCrunch that it is testing Meta AI, its large language model-powered chatbot, with WhatsApp, Instagram and Messenger users in India and parts of Africa. The move signals how Meta plans to tap massive user bases across its various apps to scale its AI offerings.

The social media giant has been scrambling to roll out more AI services in the wake of big AI moves from other major tech companies, OpenAI and more.

Meta announced plans to build and experiment with chatbots and other AI tools in [February 2023](#). India, where users have recently started noting the appearing of the Meta AI chatbot, is a very important market for the company: It is home to more than 500 million Facebook and WhatsApp users, making it Meta's largest single market.

IMAGE CREDITS: BRIAN HEATER

Developing markets, where smartphone users are growing faster than developed markets like the U.S. (where growth has plateaued), are also a big target for Facebook to try out more services to engage audiences. Users in Africa are also reporting signs of Meta AI appearing in WhatsApp.

Meta AI is now available on Nigeria whatsapp 🇳🇬

— the dildo of consequence (@Kemmo_Lala) [April 11, 2024](#)

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Meta confirmed the move in a statement. “Our generative AI-powered experiences are under development in varying phases, and we’re testing a range of them publicly in a limited capacity,” a Meta spokesperson told TechCrunch.

Meta [unveiled Meta AI](#), its general-purpose assistant, in September 2023. The AI chatbot is designed to answer user queries directly within chats as well as offer them the ability to generate photorealistic images from text prompts. In the case of Instagram, there’s evidence it’s also being used for search queries.

Meta has been somewhat late to the game for building and rolling out AI tools to its users. In part, its teams assumed that generative AI tech was not quite ready for prime time. OpenAI clearly proved that wrong, putting MetaAI on the back foot.

“The availability of ChatGPT somehow captured the attention and enthusiasm of the public,” said Yann LeCun, the Turing Award winner who is Meta’s chief AI scientist, speaking earlier this week at an “AI Day” that the company organized at its offices in

London. “What was surprising to people like me about ChatGPT was not the technology or the performance of the system. It was how much interest it gathered from the public. That surprised everyone. It surprised OpenAI, too.” Meta, he explained, thought that AI chatbots, based on its own efforts to launch them, “were not particularly welcome... in fact, some of them were trashed by people.” Now, he described the company, and the wider tech community, as “more open, and more comfortable with releasing models.”

And that’s what Meta is doing now. More pragmatically speaking, though, there are three reasons why Meta may be forging ahead with its AI strategy.

First, for user retention (users now expect to see and want to use AI tools in their apps; if Meta doesn’t offer them the worry is that those users will move away).

Second, for investor retention (investors want strong earnings, sure, but in tech they also want to see signs that Meta is committed to backing and building what many believe will be the next generation of computing).

Third, for its own pride (it’s been setting the pace for so much in areas like mobile apps, social media and advertising for the last decade, and it has outsized talent on its bench, including the celebrated AI academic Yann LeCun. Is it really going to jump the shark and miss all of this?!).

Instagram and WhatsApp’s massive global user base, boasting billions of monthly active users, to be sure presents Meta with a very unique opportunity to scale its AI offerings. By integrating Meta AI into WhatsApp and Instagram, the Facebook-parent firm can expose its advanced language model and image generation capabilities

to an enormous audience, potentially dwarfing the reach of its competitors — at least on paper.

The company separately confirmed earlier this week that it will be [launching Llama 3](#), the next version of its open source large language model, within the next month.

Omg Meta just casually dropped it's AI powered by Llama on WhatsApp 🤖🤖

pic.twitter.com/6DqnnSJ07I

— Nikhil Kumar (@nikhilkumarks) [April 12, 2024](#)

The story was updated with more detail and to note that Meta is testing also Meta AI across Instagram and Messenger alongside WhatsApp.

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